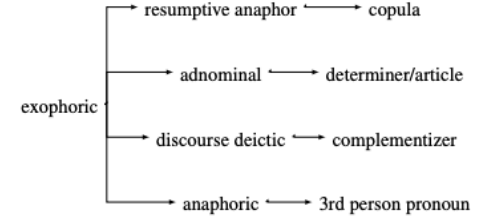


Demonstrative Shift and Proximal Markedness

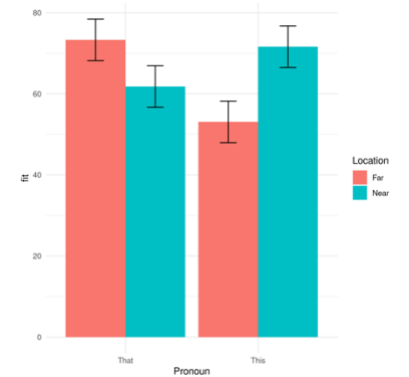
Demonstrative pronouns (*this*, *that*) making exophoric reference appear in every language (Diessel, 1999), and are involved in myriad grammaticalization clines (Greenberg, 1976; Heim, 1982; Diessel, 1999; Enfield, 2003; Konig, 2019; Sampson, 2021). In their transition from deictic exophoric pronouns to copulas, 3rd person pronouns, determiners, and complementizers, there are midway points. Each of the clines are unidirectional (Wolter, 2006; van Gelderen, 2010), but the determination of which cline to travel relies upon the exophor's syntactic positioning. While most discussion of demonstrative grammaticalization involves these trajectories, we have found little attention paid to understanding why the distal is commonly the grammaticalized demonstrative. We suggest that there is an explicit contrast of markedness of the proximal demonstrative in English relative to the unmarked use of the distal, which drives the grammaticalization of the distal. We support this claim with a quantitative study of grammaticality judgments. We propose a demonstrative logical form which reflects this markedness and connects to related work.



Data collection methodology: 70 native English speakers participated in a survey of 18 questions. Each question consisted of a 4 second video prompt that showed a speaker standing on one end of a table. There were four items of the same category on the table: two near the speaker and two far from the speaker. The speaker pointed at one item then another while stating a sentence of the format "I prefer DEM. NP to DEM. NP" with pointing accompanying each demonstrative, such as: *I like to wear [that shoe](pointing near) more than [that shoe](pointing far)*. The sentences varied between all commutations of demonstratives (proximal/distal) and locations (close, far), plus two training trials. The participants were prompted to rate each sentence on a sliding scale marked as 'Least Acceptable' to 'Most Acceptable.' Participants who completed the survey in less than four minutes were excluded from the data analysis.

Proximal pronouns are marked compared to distal demonstratives in English. Survey results confirmed that distal demonstratives are more acceptable to reference near locations than proximal demonstratives are for far locations. Judgments for the distal and the proximal in their 'matching' contexts were almost identical. There was a significant drop in grammaticality for the proximal mismatch, as compared to the distal mismatch. These data show a potential link between markedness and availability for grammaticalization toward functional items. Enfield (2003) broaches the topic in Lao demonstrative pronouns, which feature a less marked proximal form and a marked distal form (location specified for 'not-here' contexts). He claims the analysis could be extended into an English-type system for determining a similar markedness relation. **A logical form of demonstratives that considers the semantic complexity of the proximal compared to the distal would support diachronic bleaching of the demonstrative from a strong exophoric pronoun to its various later roles.** We propose treating the proximal as marked relative to distal, i.e. in all respects equivalent to the distal demonstrative with an additional restriction of proximity:

Pronoun	Location	Average	SE
That	Far	73.29	2.61
This	Near	71.60	2.61
That	Near	61.78	2.61
This	Far	53.05	2.61



$$[[this]] = \lambda P. \lambda x. P_{w0}(x) \wedge at_{w0}(x)(l_n) \wedge speaker \text{ pointing } at_{w0}(l_n) \wedge close_{w0}(l_n)$$

$$[[that]] = \lambda P. \lambda x. P_{w0}(x) \wedge at_{w0}(x)(l_n) \wedge speaker \text{ pointing } at_{w0}(l_n)$$

This definition contrasts with logical forms previously presented (Elbourne, 2005; Ahn, 2019; Wolter, 2006), which do not account for the location feature as such, but instead include [+ distal] and [+ proximal] features or do not explicitly include the location. We base the hypothesized semantic bleaching on other work which considers elements such as aspect marking and the overlapping definitions of the Spanish perfective and progressive verbal forms. This research accounts for the potential for one form to broaden its reference into the territory of another form with enough semantic and referential correspondence (Fuchs, 2019). In our case, the exophoric demonstrative that can refer to more items, regardless of location, would then be more readily available for reanalysis as functional items. Our work also speaks more broadly to synchronic preferences presenting evidence for diachronic patterns, as in Zhang, Piñango, and Deo (2019)'s study of the shift from spatial locative to possessive relations in verbs. They state that 'the convergence of synchronic and diachronic linguistic patterns...hypothesize[s] that the process of change not only operates in real-time over underlying conceptual foundations but also is actively driven by individuals' context-sensitivity during comprehension.'

In a larger typology of demonstratives, it will be fruitful to determine other aspects within the logical forms that may account for patterns of semantic bleaching in the world's languages. For example, many languages have three or more demonstratives, with only one of these grammaticalizing. There is also evidence that some languages use the proximal demonstrative to fill these functional tasks (Enfield, 2003) – could this be due to underlyingly different denotations? A full understanding of demonstratives' logical form would allow for language specific contrasts of markedness within the various demonstratives but would maintain the building blocks of the logical form to account for universals of grammaticalization paths.

Selected References Ahn, D. 2019. THAT thesis: A competition-based mechanism for anaphoric expressions. Doctoral diss., Harvard.; Deo, A. 2015. Semantic and pragmatic underpinnings of grammaticalization paths: The progressive and the imperfective. *S & P* 8 14:1-52.; Elbourne, P. 2009. Demonstratives as individual concepts. *L & P* 31(4).; Enfield, N. J. 2003. Demonstratives in space and interaction: Data from Lao speakers and implications for semantic analysis. *Language* 79(1).; Fuchs, M., et al. 2019. The Progressive-to-Imperfective shift: contextually determined variation in Rioplatense, Iberian, and Mexican Altiplano Spanish. *Issues in Hispanic and Lusophone Linguistics*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.; van Gelderen, E. 2013. The Diachrony of Pronouns and Demonstratives. in Terje Lohndal ed. *In Search of Universal Grammar: From Old Norse to Zoque*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.; Wolter, Lynsey. 2006. That's That: The Semantics and Pragmatics of Demonstrative Noun Phrases. Doctoral dissertation, UCSC.